Movie Script Writing App – Structured Development Plan

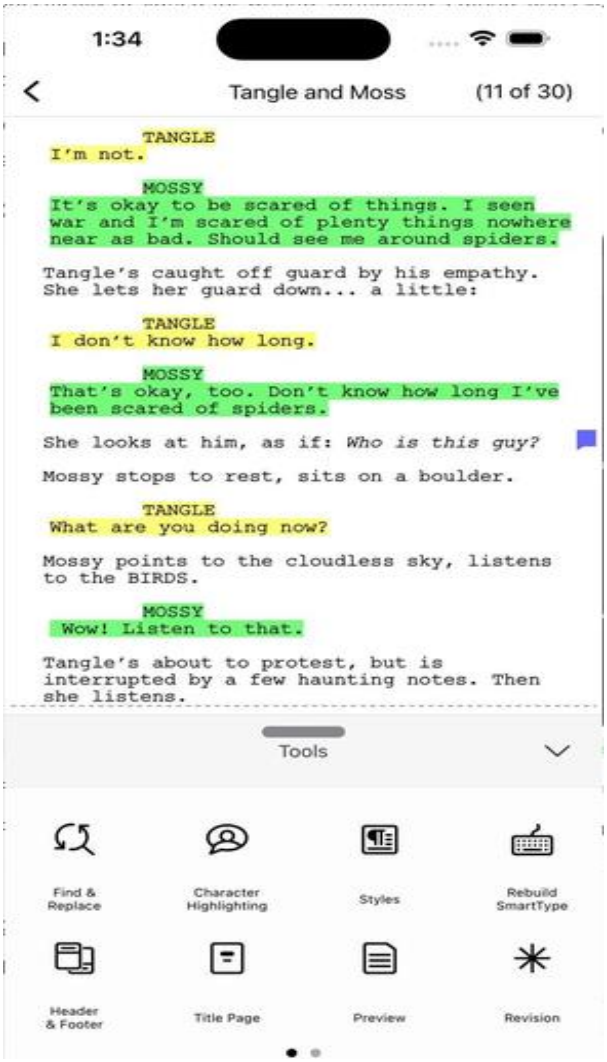
1. App overview

Proposed app concept: A mobile screenplay-writing application with an interface similar to Microsoft Word, specifically designed for writing, formatting, editing, and exporting movie scripts.

The application should provide a familiar document-editing experience while automatically applying professional screenplay formatting.

Main objective: Allow users to write movie scripts on their phones without manually adjusting margins, spacing, indentation, or screenplay elements.

Core design direction



The image shows a Permanent setting

Font: Courier

Primary interface

Layout: Word processor

Platform: Android / iOS

Output: PDF screenplay

2. Main application structure

The application can be divided into six primary sections.

1. Home / Dashboard

Access existing scripts, create new scripts, and manage documents.

2. Script Editor

Main writing environment with a Word-like editing interface.

3. Script Manager

Organize, rename, duplicate, delete, and search scripts.

4. Export / Preview

Preview screenplay pages and export documents into PDF.

5. Settings

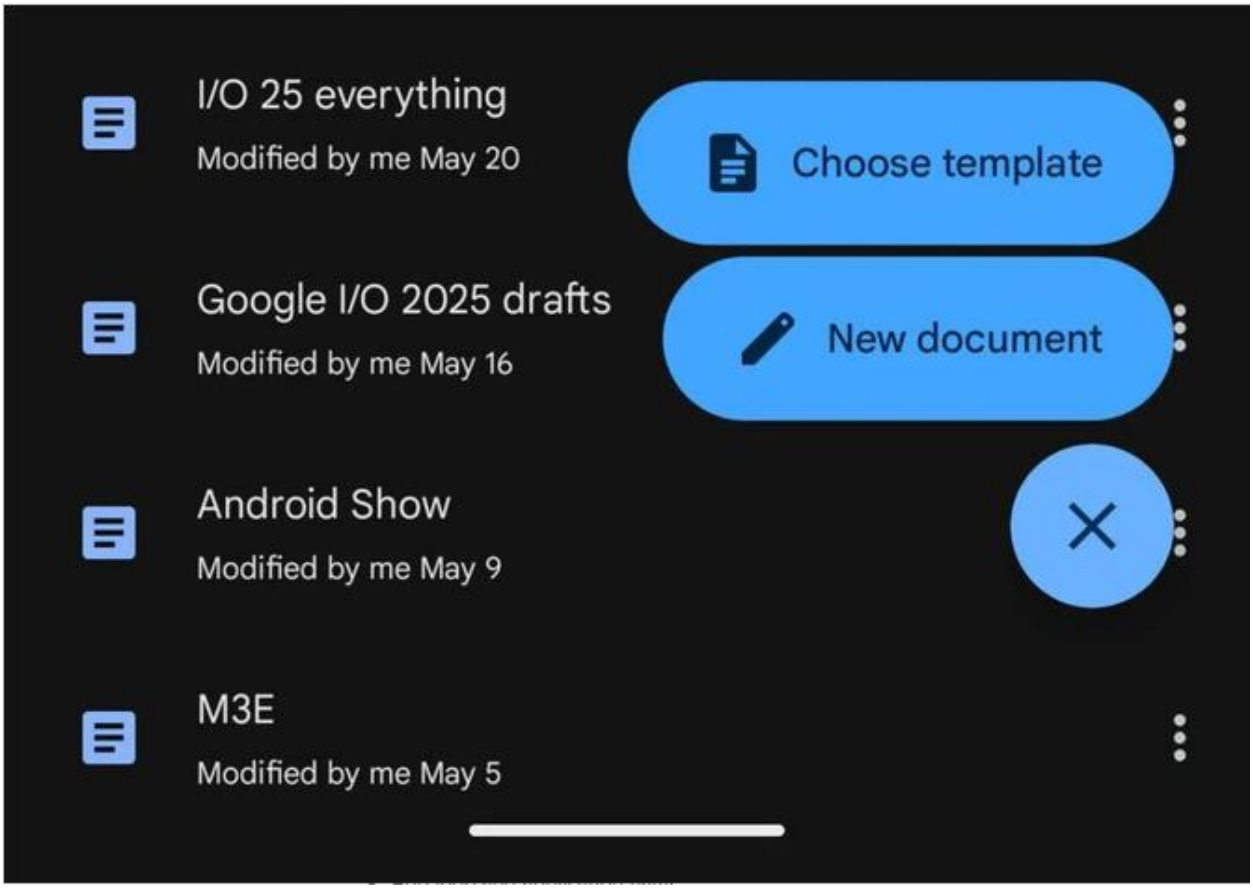
Configure document preferences, storage, and application behaviour.

6. File Management

Open, save, import, and manage the application's native script files.

3. Home screen design

The home screen should resemble a document management dashboard.



Recommended components:

- App logo and application name.
- New Script button.
- Recent Scripts section.
- Search bar.
- Folders or script collections.
- Recently modified date.
- Document settings and profile access.

New Script workflow:

1. User taps New Script.
2. Application creates a blank screenplay.
3. User enters the movie title.

4. User optionally enters writer's name.
5. Application opens the script editor.

4. Script editor – The most important component

This is the central feature of the application.

The interface should borrow the functionality of Microsoft Word while being optimized for screenplay writing.

Writing How-To: Format a Script/Screenplay | by Michelle Sommerville | Applaudience | Medium

How to Outline a Screenplay | Final Draft®

JotterPad 14 Android Update: What's In Store

10

A. Editor layout

I recommend dividing the editor into four sections.

Section	Function
Top toolbar	Save status, undo, redo, export and menu
Document area	Main screenplay writing surface
Formatting toolbar	Screenplay element selection
Keyboard area	Text input and navigation

B. Permanent font configuration

The application should have a fixed typography system.

Property	Setting
Font family	Courier
Font size	12 pt document standard
Font colour	Black
Background	White

Line spacing	Screenplay standard
Font selection	Disabled
Bold / Italic	Optional screenplay styling

Important: Users should not be able to change the font family. Every script should maintain the Courier typeface, including exported documents.

I recommend using Courier Prime or Courier New, provided the selected font is bundled with the application.

C. Screenplay formatting elements

A screenplay is different from an ordinary Word document. It uses specific formatting conventions.

The editor should support these elements:

1. Scene Heading

INT. POLICE STATION – NIGHT

Identifies location and time of day.

2. Action

John enters the room and places his bag on the table.

Describes what the audience sees and hears.

3. Character

JOHN

Identifies the speaking character.

4. Dialogue

I thought you weren't coming back tonight.

Character's spoken words.

5. Parenthetical

(whispering)

Provides an acting direction.

6. Transition

CUT TO:

Indicates a transition between scenes.

D. Formatting toolbar

Instead of forcing users to manually indent text, introduce a screenplay formatting toolbar.

Screenplay elements

Scene Heading

Action

Character

Dialogue

Parenthetical

Transition

These are formatting controls, not different fonts.

When a user selects an element, the application automatically applies the appropriate:

- Left and right indentation.
- Text alignment.
- Capitalization.
- Spacing.
- Paragraph positioning.

E. Intelligent keyboard behaviour

This is particularly important on a phone.

The editor should automatically suggest the next screenplay element.

Example workflow:

1. User writes a scene heading.
2. Presses Enter.
3. Editor automatically changes to Action.

4. User writes an action paragraph.
5. Presses Enter.
6. Editor can suggest Character.
7. User selects or enters a character name.
8. Presses Enter to move to Dialogue.
9. Presses Enter twice to return to Action.

The user should also be able to manually override the suggestions.

5. Script management and document storage

Each screenplay should exist as an independent document.

Recommended features:

- Create new script.
- Open existing script.
- Rename script.
- Duplicate script.
- Delete script.
- Organize scripts into folders.
- Search by title.
- Display last modified date.
- Automatic saving.

I recommend implementing local storage first, so users can write without an internet connection.

You can also introduce a custom file extension for the application's native screenplay documents, rather than relying exclusively on Word documents.

For example:

The_Last_Journey.sdscript

The application would recognize, open, validate, and edit its own file format.

6. Export and printing

The application should have a dedicated export system.

Format	Purpose
PDF	Printing and sharing finished scripts
Native file	Reopening and editing scripts
Fountain	Interoperability with other screenwriting tools
FDX	Compatibility with Final Draft workflows

The PDF export should preserve:

- Courier typography.
- Screenplay margins.
- Scene headings.
- Character positioning.
- Dialogue indentation.
- Page numbers.
- Page breaks.

The user should be able to preview the final screenplay before exporting.

7. Settings and additional features

Recommended settings:

Setting	Description
Auto-save	Automatically save document changes
Page display	Continuous or individual pages
Dark mode	Dark editor interface, while preserving white screenplay pages
Word count	Display total words
Page count	Display estimated screenplay pages
Find and replace	Search and edit text

Undo / redo	Reverse editing operations
Screen lock	Prevent accidental editing
Backup	Export or back up screenplay files

Additional features to consider later:

- Character name recognition.
- Scene numbering.
- Scene navigation.
- Character dialogue statistics.
- Revision history.
- Screenplay collaboration.
- Script version comparison.

8. Recommended technology stack

Since you're considering React Native development, this would be a suitable architecture.

Application architecture

React Native Mobile Application

User interface and navigation

Screenplay Editor

Text input, formatting, keyboard behaviour and pagination.

Document Manager

File creation, loading, saving and validation.

Local Storage

SQLite or filesystem-based storage.

PDF Generator

Screenplay page rendering and PDF export.

Native Screenplay File

Your application's custom file format

Suggested development technologies

Component	Technology
Mobile framework	React Native + Expo
Programming language	JavaScript
Navigation	React Navigation
Editor	Custom rich-text editor or structured screenplay editor
Local database	SQLite
File handling	Expo FileSystem
PDF generation	HTML-to-PDF or PDF library
Font	Bundled Courier font
Backend	Not required initially

Do you need MongoDB?

No. Not for the initial application.

If the application saves scripts locally, you can build the entire first version without MongoDB or an online backend. Cloud synchronization and collaboration can be introduced later.

9. Development roadmap

I recommend building the application in phases rather than developing every feature simultaneously.

1. Phase 1 – Application foundation
    - Home screen.
    - New script creation.
    - Navigation.
    - Document manager.
2. Phase 2 – Screenplay editor

    - Courier font integration.
    - Text editing.
    - Screenplay element formatting.
    - Keyboard behaviour.
    - Undo and redo.
3. Phase 3 – Document management
    - Native file structure.
    - Save and load.
    - Auto-save.
    - File validation.
4. Phase 4 – Screenplay layout
    - Standard screenplay margins.
    - Page breaks.
    - Pagination.
    - Page numbering.
5. Phase 5 – Export
    - PDF generation.
    - Preview.
    - Printing and sharing.
6. Phase 6 – Advanced features
    - Character recognition.
    - Scene management.
    - Backup.
    - Cloud synchronization.

10. Minimum viable product (MVP)

Your first working version should only contain these features:

MVP development checklist

0/14 completed

Create a new screenplay

Open and edit existing screenplays

Permanent Courier font

12-point screenplay typography

Scene heading formatting

Action formatting

Character formatting

Dialogue formatting

Parenthetical formatting

Transition formatting

Automatic saving

Custom screenplay file format

PDF export

Page numbering and pagination

My recommendation: Prioritize the screenplay editor and its formatting engine above everything else. A visually attractive Word-like interface is relatively straightforward; the more important engineering challenge is making screenplay text behave correctly, automatically format itself, and maintain professional page layouts.